

Threat Actors:

The Entity responsible for an event that has an impact on the safety of another entity:

- Also called a malicious actor

Threat Actor attributes:

- Describes characteristics of the attacker

Useful to categorize the motivation:

- Why is the attack happening?
- Is this directed or random

Attributes of threat Actors

Internal/external:

- The attacker is inside the house
- They're outside and trying to get in

Resources/funding;

- No money
- Extensive funding

Level of sophistication:

- Blindly run scripts or automated vulnerability scans
- Can write their own attack malware and scripts

Motivations of threat actors:

What makes them tick?

- There's a purpose to this attack

Motivations include:

- Data Exfiltration
- Espionage
- Service disruption
- Blackmail
- Financial Gain
- Philosophical/political beliefs
- Ethical
- Revenge
- Disruption/chaos
- War

Nation states

External entity:

- Government and nation security

Many Possible motivations

- Data exfiltration, Philosophical, revenge, disruption, war

Constant attacks, massive resources:

- Commonly Advanced Persistent Threat (APT)

Highest sophistication:

- Military control, utilities, financial control
- United States and Israel destroyed 1000 nuclear centrifuges with the Stuxnet worm

Unskilled attackers:

Runs premade scripts without any knowledge of what's really happening:

- Anyone can do this

Motivated by the hunt:

- Disruption, data exfil, sometimes philosophical

Can be internal or external:

- Usually external

Not very sophisticated:

- Limited resources, if any

No formal funding:

- Looking for low hanging fruit

Hacktivist:

A hacker with a purpose:

- Motivated by philosophy, revenge, disruption, etc.

Often an external entity;

- Could potentially infiltrate to also be an insider threat

Can be remarkably sophisticated:

- Very specific hacks
- DoS, web site defacing, private document release

Funding may be limited:

- Some organizations have fundraising options

Insider threat:

More than a password on sticky notes:

- Motivated by revenge, financial gain

Extensive resources:

- Using the organizations resources against themselves

An internal entity:

- Eating away from the inside

Medium level sophistication:

- The insider has institutional knowledge

- Attacks can be directed at vulnerable systems
- The insider knows what to hit

Organized crime:

Professional criminals:

- Motivated by money
- Almost always an external entity

Very sophisticated:

- Best hacking money can buy

Crime that's organized:

- One hacks, one manages the exploits, one sells the data, one handles customer support

Lots of capital to fun hacking efforts

Shadow IT

Going rogue:

- Working around the internal IT organization
- Builds their own infrastructure

Information Technology can put up road blocks:

- Shadow IT is unencumbered
- Use the cloud
- Might also be able to innovate

Limited resources:

- Company budget

Medium sophistication;

- May not have IT training or knowledge

Threat Actors:



Threat actor	Attributes			Possible motivations
	Location	Resources	Sophistication	
Nation state	External	Extensive	Very high	Data exfiltration, philosophical, revenge, disruption, war
Unskilled	External	Limited	Very low	Disruption, data exfiltration, philosophical beliefs
Hacktivist	External	Some funding	Can be high	Philosophical beliefs, revenge, disruption/chaos
Insider threat	Internal	Many resources	Medium	Revenge, financial gain
Organized crime	External	Often extensive	Very high	Financial
Shadow IT	Internal	Many resources	Limited	Philosophical beliefs, revenge

